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Stance and Register Variation in Philippine English

Quantitative Evidence from Media Coverage of a National Controversy

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Overview

1 **Introduction**: Context, Research Focus, Research Questions

2 **Literature Review and Methodology**: Theoretical Foundations, Computational Methodology

3 **Quantitative Results**: Lexical Bias, Quotation Diversity, Temporal Sentiment Polarity

4 **Discussion**: Framing and Lexical Bias, Register, Sourcing, and Style

5 **Conclusion and Future Work**: Summary of Key Findings, Future Directions

Context: The Flood Control Controversy

A major large-scale corruption scandal erupted over allegedly anomalous flood-control infrastructure projects, gained popularity starting in mid-2024.

Billions of pesos (PHP 180B ≈ JPY 480B) were allegedly allocated to nonexistent or substandard infrastructure—known as **ghost projects.**

Timeline

Alarm raised publicly

August 2024

Floods intensify criticism

October 2024

Marcos vetoes budget

December 2024

SONA claims completion

July 2025

Philippines Under Water

August 2025

Trillion Peso March and mass protests

September 2025

ICI investigations

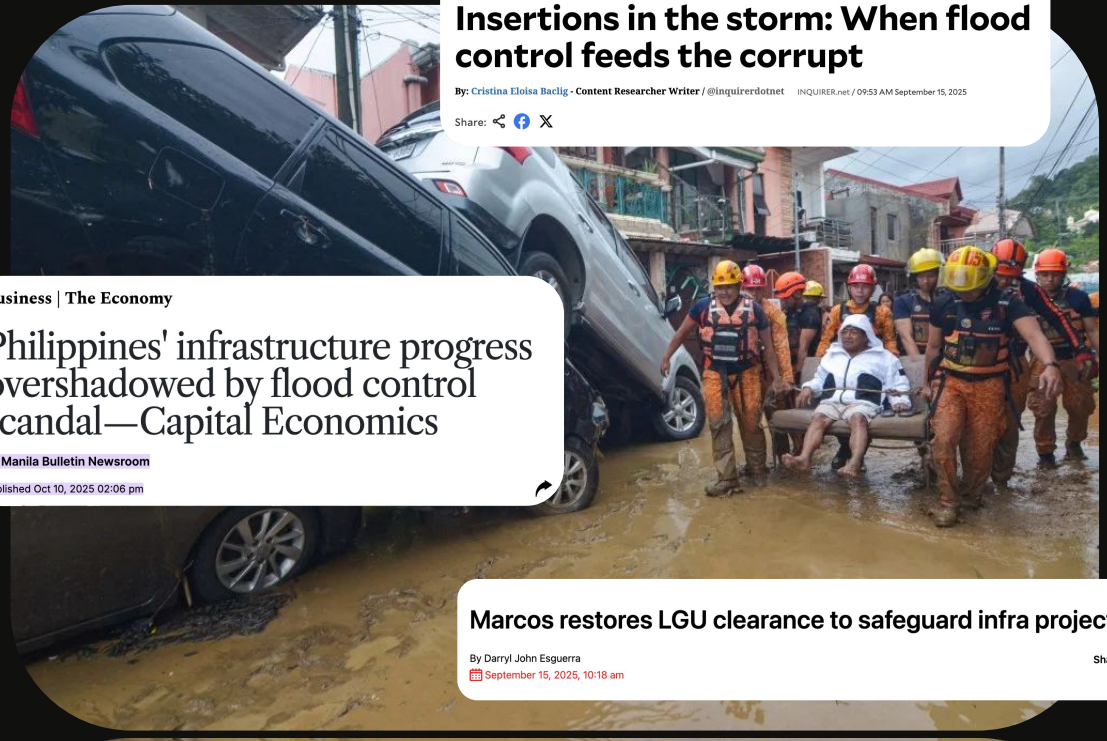
October 2025

Officials arrested

November 2025

The challenge

News outlets framed this issue in distinct ways, using varying language and journalistic registers to serve different agenda and evoke motions from intended readership.



NATION

Insertions in the storm: When flood control feeds the corrupt

By: Cristina Eloisa Baclig - Content Researcher Writer / @inquirerdotnet INQUIRER.net / 09:53 AM September 15, 2025

Share:

Business | The Economy

Philippines' infrastructure progress overshadowed by flood control scandal—Capital Economics

By Manila Bulletin Newsroom

Published Oct 10, 2025 02:06 pm

Marcos restores LGU clearance to safeguard infra projects

By Darryl John Esguerra

September 15, 2025, 10:18 am

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Research Questions

1

Lexical bias

What bias dimensions emerge from word choices across outlets?

2

Register variation

How do conventions (e.g., number of quoted sources, tone) differ by outlet?

3

Implications

What do these differences reveal about Philippine English as a register-diverse variety?

An Outer-Circle Variety

- widely recognized as an Outer-Circle variety of English
- indigenized and nativized through a century of use
- already undergoing endonormative stabilization (Borlongan, 2016)

Internal Diversity

- not monolithic; research emphasizes it is internally diverse and context-dependent
- variation arises across regions, social groups, and registers
- media discourse is one key domain to observe this variation
- English of Philippine news reflects both global journalistic norms and local linguistic flavor.

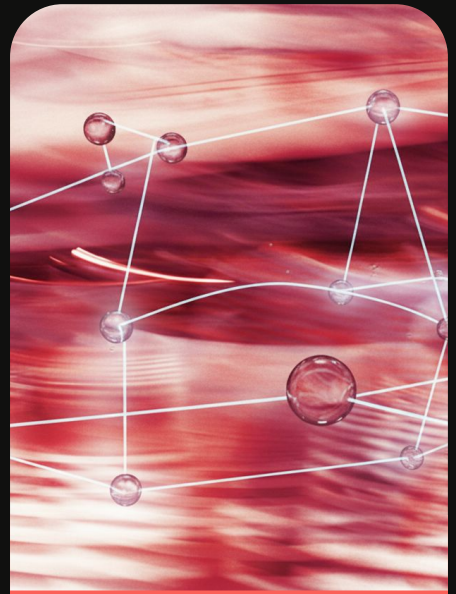
PhE news register

- Register refers to systematic differences in language use depending on context and purpose.
- News is characterized by high information density, attribution to sources, and a formal tone.
- This study quantifies register variation and ideological stance across English-language news outlets in the Philippines.

Lexical Media Bias

Subtle Signaling

- word choice
- slant
- frames



Quantifying Bias

- computational approaches
- corpus statistics

Interpreting

- qualitative
- bias axis

Computational methodology

1. Data collection
2. Exploratory data analysis
3. Principal component analysis
4. Quote diversity analysis
5. Temporal sentiment analysis

Data collection

- Collected ~500 URLs of English articles via Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone (GDELT) localized in the Philippines from September 1, 2025 to October 20, 2025, through the keyword search “flood control”.
- Built a Python program to access each URL and scrape the structured news via Trafilatura, Newspaper3k, and Readability
- After text extraction and data cleaning, only 408 articles remained intact for further analysis.

Exploratory data analysis

- Outlet aggregate counts
- Word counts

Term frequency-inverse document frequency (TF-IDF) and principal component analysis (PCA) (D'Alonzo & Tegmark, 2022)

- TF-IDF was used to identify words unique to each outlet compared to the entire corpus.
- Principal Component Analysis (PCA) was then applied to the TF-IDF output to determine the main axes (PC1, PC2) of word usage variation.
- Note on method: While the original study employed Poisson singular value decomposition (SVD) for PCA, this study utilizes truncated SVD due to a smaller data size.

Methods

Quote diversity analysis

- Each outlet represented as a bubble → bubble size = diversity of quoted speakers
- Speaker diversity measured by distinct entity types in quotation marks (e.g., official, NGO, student, citizen)
- Captures an “official-source vs. multi-source” divide as a measurable form of bias

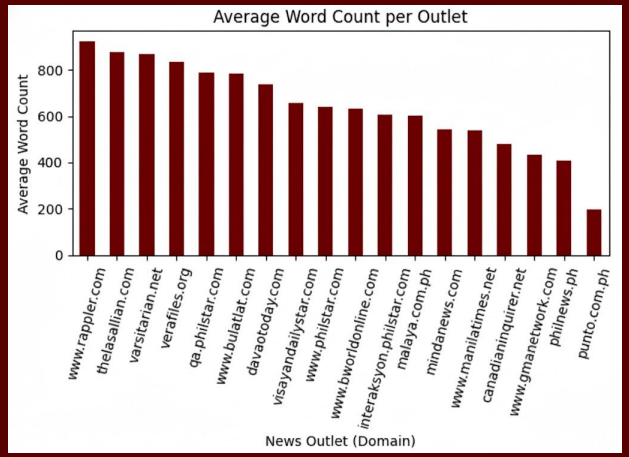
Temporal sentiment analysis

- Use VADER to compute sentiment score and labeled each article as positive, negative, or neutral.
- Group articles by date to calculate daily sentiment counts.
- Detect spike days based on unusually high total or negative article volume.
- Use TF-IDF to extract top keywords for each spike day.
- Visualize daily sentiment trends and annotated spikes with event-related terms.

EDA Results

- Philstar.com, Rappler, The Manila Times, and Business World Online dominate coverage, making up over half of all articles.
- Average word count varies greatly across outlets.
- Independent and university-based sources (e.g., Rappler, The LaSallian) publish longer, more analytical pieces.
- Smaller or regional sites tend to produce shorter reports.
- Variation suggests differing editorial styles and reporting depth across Philippine English media.

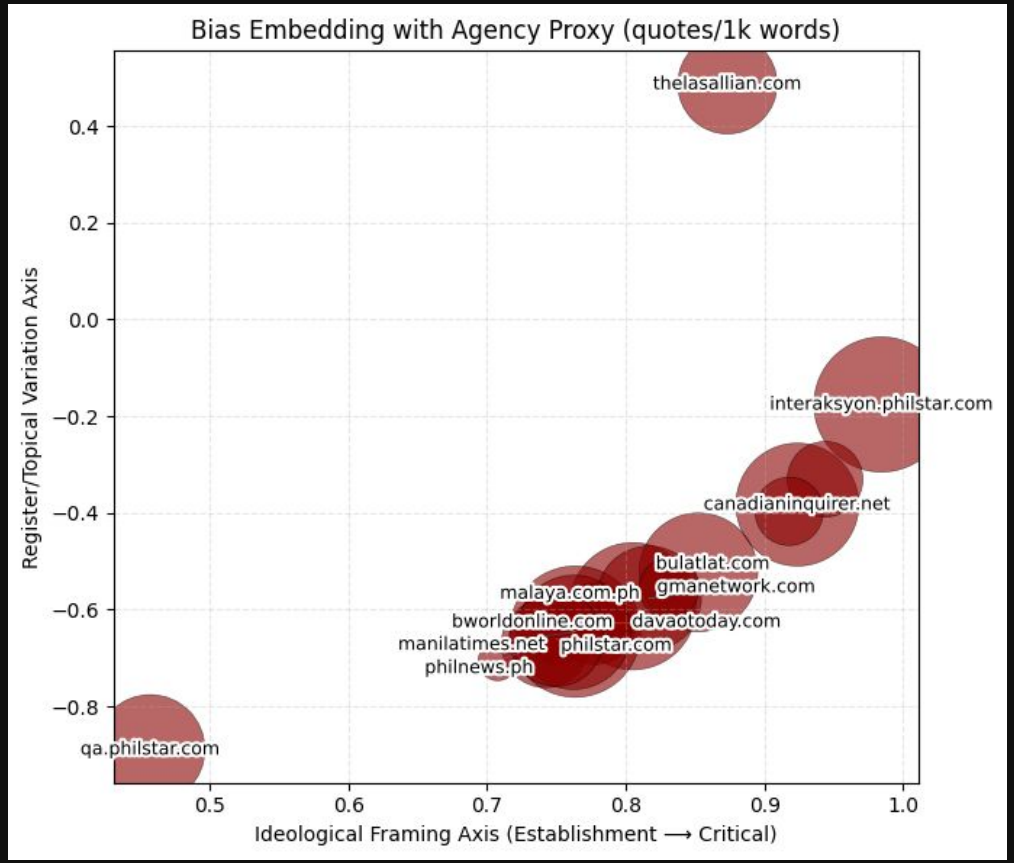
News Outlet (Domain)	Article Count
www.philstar.com ↗	137
www.rappler.com ↗	65
www.manilatimes.net ↗	53
www.bworldonline.com ↗	53
malaya.com.ph	44
mindanews.com	13
interaksyon.philstar.com	7
visayandailystar.com	7
canadianinquirer.net	6
verafiles.org	5



Linguistic Density and Registers

- Word count variation signals register differences.
  - Longer pieces (Rappler, The LaSallian) use the Fact-Centered Register: high information density via complex nominalizations (e.g., "flood-control infrastructure projects") and formal, policy-level language.
  - Shorter regional or opinion-based articles use the Editorial/Brief Register: more colloquial, local idioms, or local identity markers, reflecting a conversational style.

PCA & Quote Diversity Results



- Each bubble represents a news outlet's language patterns.
- X-axis: Ideological Framing (establishment to critical language).
- Y-axis: Register Variation (formal reporting to conversational style).
- Bubble size: Quote diversity (distinct voices in coverage).
- *The LaSallian* and *Interaksyon* show high voice diversity and critical framing.
- *Philstar.com* and *The Manila Times* lean establishment with narrower sourcing.
- Rightward outlets use emotive, people-centered terms (*"resign," "protester," "corruption"*).
- Leftward outlets favor technical, institutional terms (*"audit issue", "step down", "citizen"*).

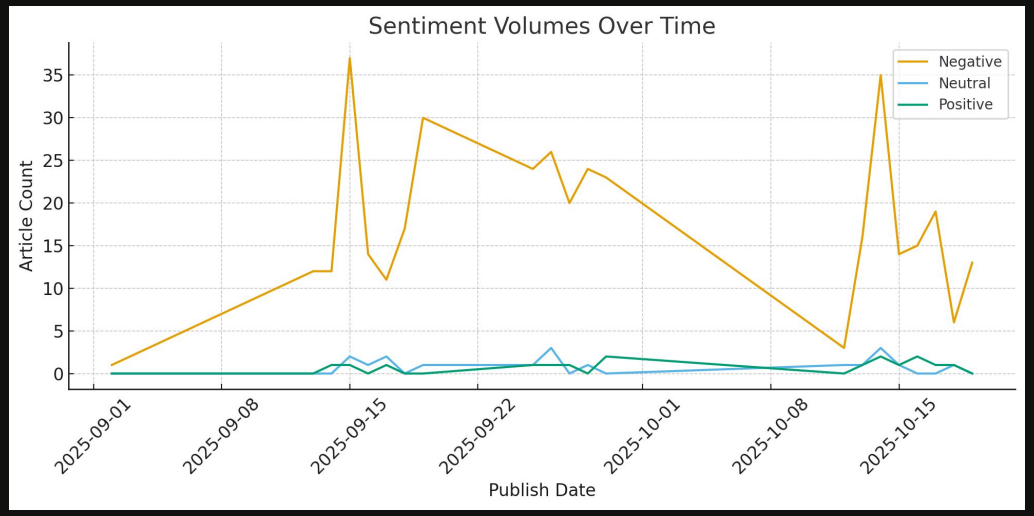
Word Choice as Stancing

- Outlets "critical" in the PCA axes use the semantic field of moralized action with emotive, personalized expressions like the direct verb "resign" and the noun "corruption" to express outrage and identify actors.
- Conversely, "establishment" outlets employ the semantic field of bureaucracy and procedure, favoring formal, institutional terms like "audit issue" and the phrasal verb "step down," framing the controversy as a technical or procedural breakdown.

Temporal Sentiment Analysis Results

Sentiment Spikes and Key Events

- **Sept 15 2025 – Protest & Corruption Uproar**
  - Marcos Jr. addressed protests over alleged ₱545-billion “ghost projects.”
  - Media coverage spiked around *corruption*, *DPWH*, and *Senate probes*.
- **Sept 18 2025 – Mass Protests**
  - Preparations for nationwide protests against corruption
- **Oct 14 2025 – Financial Fallout & Public Outrage**
  - BSP warned of risks tied to the scandal; reports on *flood projects* and *billions lost* trended.
  - Surveys showed most Filipinos believed officials were involved.



Sentiment analysis showed a consistently negative affect across all outlets.

Sustained Negative Affect

- The consistently negative affect found in the sentiment analysis is sustained across registers by the pervasive use of evaluative words.
- This includes specific "loaded language" and moralized nouns (e.g., "ghost projects," "kickbacks") that carry inherent negative semantic load.

Discussion: Register and Source Use

- **Sourcing as Register Style**: An outlet's style is consciously reflected in its quote selection and frequency.
- **Fact-Centered Register**: High quote counts (e.g., BusinessWorld) show thorough sourcing, quoting multiple experts and officials to maintain a formal, objective style.
- **Advocacy Register**: Uses quotes from activists and critics to directly support its political stance and journalistic purpose (e.g., Bulatlat).
- **Editorial/Brief Register**: Low quote counts signal shorter articles or subjective commentary, common in regional or opinion-based pieces.
- **Ideological Impact**: Outlets use sourcing to foreground their stance: sympathetic media emphasize administration allies, while critical media focus on opposition figures and victims.

Discussion: Implications for PhE

- **Wide Register Range**: The results show that Philippine English (PhE) has a broad register range, adapting to various communicative needs.
- **Seamless Switching**: Journalists easily move between formal, policy-level language (e.g., technical budgets) and colloquial or loaded language (e.g., expressing direct outrage).
- **Nativized Adaptation**: Code-switching (leaving Taglish untranslated) and the use of local identity markers demonstrate the creative and nativized nature of PhE.
- **Discourse Mediation**: PhE media reframes global or vernacular expressions (like "nepo baby") within local narratives, acting as a mediator of emerging discourse.

Conclusion and Future Directions

1. Key Finding 1 (Differentiation): Philippine English (PhE) shows systematic, quantifiable intra-varietal register variation in lexical selection and sourcing practices, linked to institutional stance.
2. Key Finding 2 (Stance Realization): Ideological bias is linguistically realized through selective use of semantic fields (bureaucratic vs. moralized lexis), showing how stance is coded via subtle word choice.
3. Contribution: This provides empirical evidence that register diversity is a salient dimension of stabilized English varieties, supporting the model of PhE nearing Schneider's Phase 5 (Differentiation).
4. Expand study to more outlets and a more fine-grained time interval via News on the Web (NOW) corpus.

Thank you!

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